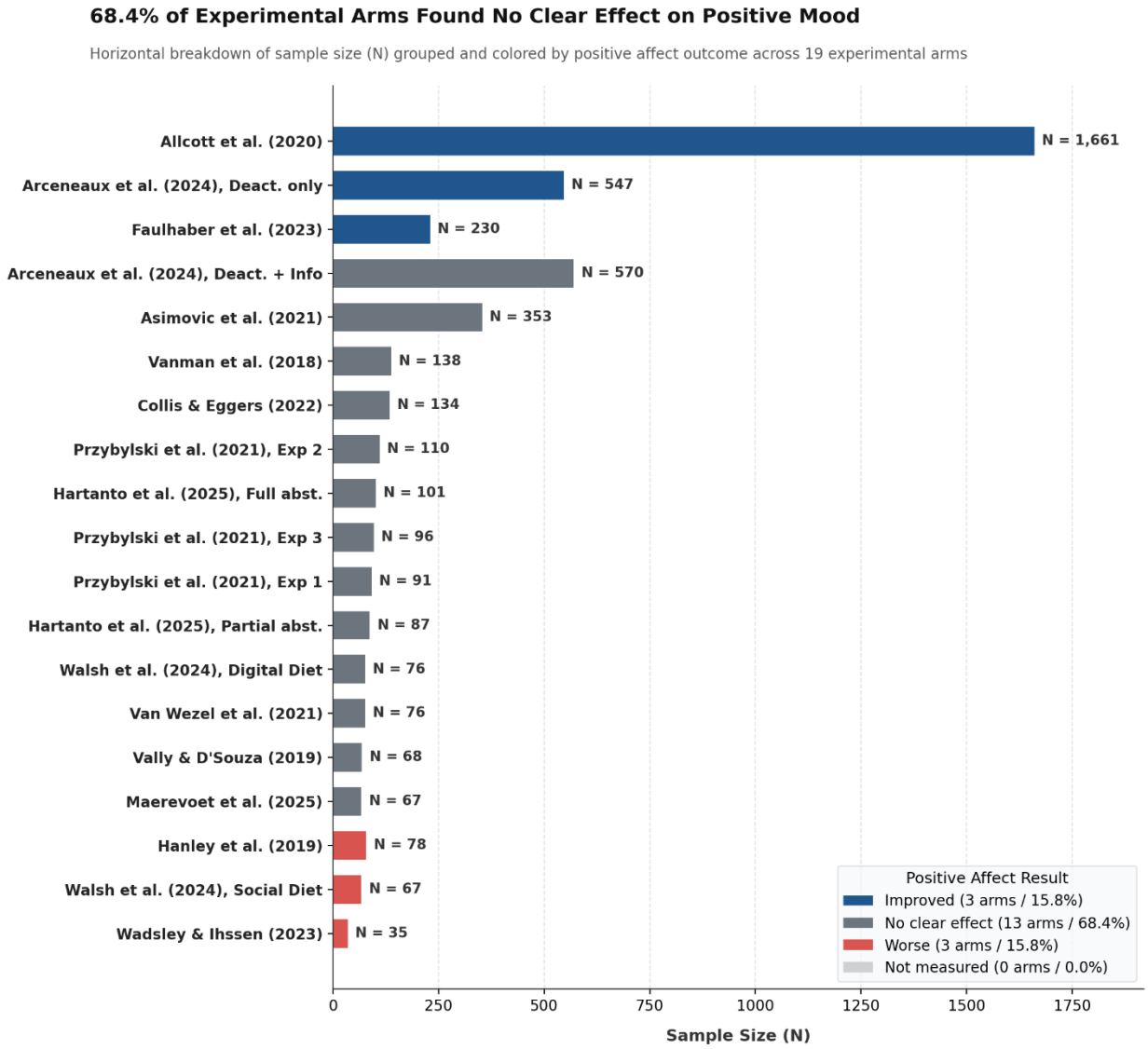
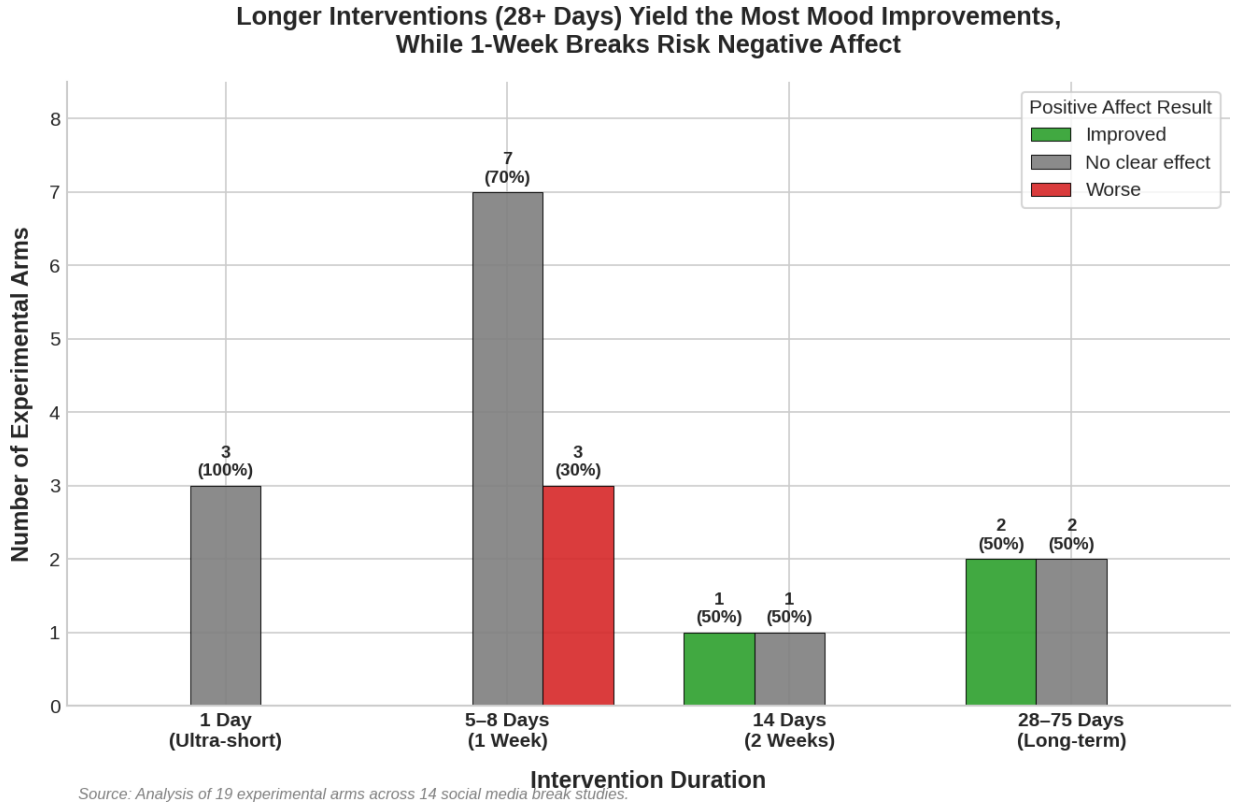
1. **Summary of the evidence**

We reviewed 14 experiments in which people were asked to quit or cut down on social media. For positive mood, 3 found an improvement [Allcott et. al. 2020; Arceneaux et al. 2024 (Deact. Only)]; [Faulhaber et al. 2023 (Deact. + Info)], [Faulhaber et al. (2023)].



Source: 14 uploaded study PDF files across 19 experimental arms.

The breaks were short, lasting between 1 day and 75 days, and most participants were university students from different countries like Hong Kong, UAE, UK and US etc.



Studies that asked people to quit completely found a positive result on their daily usage, while studies that asked people to cut down, found no clear effect . The largest study, AllCott et a.(2020), with 1,661 participants “IMPROVED” their result. Overall, these studies suggest that every individual may have different outcomes based on a specific study. Those who decided to restrain from using social media ended accustoming themself to that behavior, which was staying out of social media for good. While those who minimized their social media time ended up using it more or less because they could not see a major improvement during or after the study.

Study	Design	Sample description	Intervention	Positive affect result

Allcott et al. (2020)	RCT	2,743 baseline / 1,661 impact sample; US adult Facebook users	Quit; Facebook; 28 days	**Improved**
Arceneaux et al. (2024), Deactivation only	RCT	2,246 total (547 in Deactivation only group); eligible voters, France	Quit; Facebook; 28 days	**Improved**
Arceneaux et al. (2024), Deactivation + Information	RCT	2,246 total (570 in Deactivation + Info group); eligible voters, France	Quit; Facebook (plus informational messages); 28 days	**No clear effect**
Asimovic et al. (2021)	RCT	556 total (353 analyzed); Facebook users, Bosnia and Herzegovina	Quit; Facebook; 7 days	**No clear effect**
Collis & Eggers (2022)	RCT	191 (134 in treatment block); university students, Netherlands	Limit; Facebook, Instagram, Snapchat; max 10 min/day; 75 days	**No clear effect**
Faulhaber et al. (2023)	RCT	230; undergraduate university students, US	Limit; 10 social apps; 30 min/day total; 14 days	**Improved**
Hanley et al. (2019)	Non-randomised experiment	78; adults aged 18–48, Australia, UK, US	Quit; Facebook and Instagram; 7 days	**Worse**

Hartanto et al. (2025), Full abstinence	RCT	280 total (101 in full abstinence); university students, Singapore	Quit; major social media platforms; 7 days	**No clear effect**
Hartanto et al. (2025), Partial abstinence	RCT	280 total (87 in partial abstinence); university students, Singapore	Limit; major social media platforms; 10 min/app/day; 7 days	**No clear effect**
Maerevoet et al. (2025)	RCT	67 (35 experimental, 32 control); university students with high use (≥2 hr/day), Belgium	Limit; preferred social media apps; max 30 min/day; 14 days	**No clear effect**
Przybylski et al. (2021), Experiment 1	Within-person	91; young adults / university students, UK	Quit; all social media; 1 day	**No clear effect**
Przybylski et al. (2021), Experiment 2	Within-person	110; young adults / university students, US	Quit; all social media; 1 day	**No clear effect**
Przybylski et al. (2021), Experiment 3	Within-person	96; young adults / university students, Hong Kong	Quit; all social media; 1 day	**No clear effect**

Vally & D'Souza (2019)	RCT	78 (68 analyzed); university students, UAE	Quit; all social media; 7 days	**No clear effect**
Vanman et al. (2018)	RCT	138; active Facebook users / university students, Australia	Quit; Facebook; 5 days	**No clear effect**
Van Wezel et al. (2021)	RCT	76; university students, Netherlands	Limit; Facebook, Instagram, Snapchat, YouTube; 50% reduction; 7 days	**No clear effect**
Wadsley & Ihssen (2023)	Within-person	51 (35 analyzed for mood); university students / young adults, UK	Quit; all social media (SNS); 7 days	**Worse**
Walsh et al. (2024), Social Diet	RCT	414 total (67 analyzed in Social Diet); university students (Gen Z), US	Limit; Facebook, Instagram, Twitter, Snapchat; restrict as much as possible; 8 days	**Worse**

Walsh et al. (2024), Digital Diet	RCT	414 total (76 analyzed in Digital Diet); university students (Gen Z), US	Limit; smartphone digital media (gaming, social media, entertainment, news); restrict as much as possible; 8 days

The above table did not find any type of relation or evidence to link the abstinence of using social media of a w

*** I used Gemini Notebook (Google, 10/18/2026) to extract details from 14 studies. I checked 5 of them against the articles and all were correct.